

Lions center Cade Mays to miss 'significant' time with wrist injury



The Lions will be without center Cade Mays for an extended period of time, coach Dan Campbell said Monday. Junfu Han / Imagn Images



By **Colton Pouncy**

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ALLEN PARK, Mich. — In a major blow to an offensive line that needed all the help it could get, Detroit Lions center Cade Mays suffered a wrist injury in practice and will now miss a “significant period of time,” coach Dan Campbell said Monday.

The Athletic confirmed that Mays is expected to be sidelined 8-10 weeks.

The Lions signed Mays, a free agent, to a three-year contract in the offseason as a bid to address one of their biggest needs. Center had been a team weakness since the sudden retirement of All-Pro center Frank Ragnow in June 2025. The Lions struggled to create running lanes in the interior and protect QB Jared Goff last season, which led to an inefficient offense in 2025. Graham Glasgow, Kingsley Eguakun and Trystan Colon couldn't get the job done, and the Lions like Tate Ratledge better at right guard — hence the need for Mays.

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Mays has been playing center full-time in the NFL for two seasons and he has not allowed a sack in that span. The Lions coveted his size and ability to anchor in pass protection, and zeroed in on him in free agency when they surveyed the center market. He was the lone player the Lions signed to a multiyear contract during the period. In his first training camp with the team, Mays was getting valuable reps with the offense and becoming familiar with his new linemates and with new offensive coordinator Drew Petzing. Now, he'll miss extended time and will need to hit the ground running upon his return.

Campbell wouldn't put a timeline on Mays' return, but said he'll be back before the playoffs. If it's closer to the 8-10 week timeline, Mays could potentially return following Detroit's Week 6 bye — an Oct. 25 game vs. the Packers in Week 7. The Lions will likely turn to Juice Scruggs to fill the void, but he's dealing with a soft tissue injury and will need a few days, per Campbell. Seth McLaughlin, a 2025 UDFA out of Ohio State, received all of the first-team reps at center in Monday's practice with Scruggs out. The results were mixed.

Given Mays' consistency in pass protection, he'll be missed.

Colton Pouncy is a staff writer for The Athletic covering the Detroit Lions. He previously covered Michigan State football and basketball for the company, and covered sports for The Tennessean in Nashville prior to joining The Athletic.

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